

Voices in Unity

Various and differentiating perspectives are intrinsic gears in the machine of collaboration. To advance a community or society in which everyone has the opportunity to participate in government, collaboration is an absolute necessity. The lack of cooperation between people with different views can lead to instability and the concentration of power in the hands of those at the top of the political hierarchy. Today, the political parties of the United States have become increasingly polarized, mainly due to a few divisive issues. One's opinions on topics such as gun control, abortion, and the Israel-Palestine conflict can single-handedly dictate whether someone is 'claimed' by Democrats or Republicans.

As a student at SI, I notice the division between people with various political ideologies is constantly being fueled in my friendships, sports teams, and on the Internet. Opinions instantly form when one identifies with a political party, and harmful and destructive stereotypes exist on both sides, making it increasingly challenging to foster cohesion and progress forward. When collaboration disappears from a government, democracy begins to erode, and the voice of the people is gradually silenced. A notable example of the erosion of democracy due to polarization is the Spanish government's structure in the 1930s.

Hatred boiled between the left-leaning Republicans and the right-leaning Nationalists as the Second Republic (the Spanish parliamentary system at the time) was crippled by infighting and extremism. Legislature in the center of the political spectrum was impossible to pass as compromise was seen as a sign of disloyalty, leading the centrists to be seen as outcasts and traitors. The absence of collaboration created an irreparable instability which enabled Francisco Franco to seize power and lead a brutal

45-year dictatorship. When a country's leaders refuse to work together and acknowledge other viewpoints and perspectives, the voice of the community is drowned out. This is precisely why collaboration between conflicting views can lead to unity and social progression, similar to the union of South Africa's government in the 1990s.

In contrast to the failure of compromise in Spain, South Africa offers a rare example of reconciliation succeeding against the odds. South Africa had suffered from years of apartheid, causing racial division to be ingrained in society and infecting every aspect of South African life. However, the white minority government led by F.W. de Klerk made the unexpected move to push for peace and equality with the African National Congress led by Nelson Mandela. Mandela and de Klerk worked together to negotiate a peaceful transition to democracy, finally allowing the historically oppressed Black majority of South Africa's population to influence policy and government. This collaboration between these two groups that had clashed for so long avoided what many thought to be inevitable violence and bloodshed, laying the foundation for national reconciliation and a more inclusive society.

In examining both historical and contemporary examples, it becomes clear that collaboration plays a critical role. It is not just beneficial, but essential to a functioning, unified, and diverse society. The consequences of a government's refusal to be open to various viewpoints becomes quite clear. When collaboration dissolves, it creates an opening for authoritarianism to contaminate communities that previously had been able to work towards a common goal. When compromise and cooperation are embraced and furthered, every citizen has a say in the structure of their government, leading to innovation and inclusivity.

One man who made the ultimate sacrifice to protect these values was none other than Admiral Daniel J. Callaghan. Callaghan was known as an exemplary role model, being appointed by President Franklin D. Roosevelt as his naval aid after finding success as the lieutenant of the USS Colorado. Additionally, Callaghan was extremely selfless and always looking to help others in need. Off the coast of Ireland, he convinced the captain of his vessel to rescue a disabled British ocean liner, even when the captain claimed it was impossible. It is for this reason that I believe Admiral Callaghan was so revered during his service and to this day. He fought for a government whose very core functions through uplifting each one of its citizens and encouraging collaboration and unity between people from all walks of life.

In many ways, the battle in which Admiral Callaghan heroically gave his life represented the exact clash of values that I've spent this essay writing about. On November 13, 1942, Admiral Callaghan led U.S. naval forces against Japanese warships in the Naval Battle of Guadalcanal. Sadly, enemy fire killed him and members of his command staff during the battle. Ultimately, this was one of the most significant events in World War II, as the U.S. forces and Admiral Callaghan's sacrifice defeated Japan's final major attempt to usurp Allied power in Guadalcanal and halt Japan's expansion in the Pacific region.

However, its significance also lies in the principles and ideals going head to head between the U.S. and Japan. The United States joined WWII as a beacon of democracy, unity, and collaboration, and was pitted against Japan's authoritarian regime. During the war, the Japanese government exercised strict censorship and considered dissenting views as disloyal and treasonous. Power was concentrated in the hands of the military

elite, who faced virtually no checks or balances from other branches of the government, very similar to the structure of the dictatorship of Francisco Franco in the 1930s.

Admiral Callaghan's death was a sacrifice in the name of democratic collaboration, as he led alongside his men while promoting unity and embodying democratic values enemies during wartime. The Spanish and South African governments in the 20th century and the clash between the ideals of the U.S. and Japan in WWII prove that democracy thrives where collaboration is valued, and authoritarianism rises where collaboration is punished, causing the people to lose their voice as power becomes collected in the hands of the few instead of the many. Collaboration is indispensable to any society hoping to progress socially, politically, and economically, as it exposes leaders to various viewpoints and new ideas.